

Session 9: Deceiving the Deceiver

Key Takeaways

- As a disguised deceiver, Tamar turns the Eden deception on its head as she deceives her deceiver in order to preserve life.
- In the social world of the biblical characters, widows and sex workers are some of the most vulnerable members of society. Tamar further exposes herself to risk and stigma in order to overcome Yehudah's failure to care for her.
- The stories of Tamar, Lot's daughters, and Ruth form a three-part birth narrative for David's lineage.

The Design and Message of Genesis 38:12-23

¹² And the days were many
and **the daughter of Shua**, the wife of Yehudah, died;
and Yehudah was comforted,
and he went up to his shearers of **his flock** at Timnah,
he and **his friend Hirah the Adullamite**.
¹³ And it was reported to Tamar,
"Behold, your father-in-law is going up to Timnah to shear **his flock**."

¹⁴ **And she removed her widow's garments**
A **and she covered with a veil,**
and she wrapped herself,
and she sat at the door of "Two eyes",
which is **by the road** to Timnah;
A **because she saw that** Shelah had grown up,
and she had not been given to him as a **wife**.
¹⁵ And **Yehudah saw her,**
B and he reckoned her to be a **prostitute**,
because **she had covered her face**.
¹⁶ And **he turned aside to her by the road,**
A' and he said,
"Come now, please, **let me go in to you**,"
because he did not know that she was **his daughter-in-law**.
And **she** said, "**What will you give me**, that **you may come in to me**?"
A

¹⁷ And **he** said, "I will send you a young goat from the flock."
 And **she** said, "If **you will give** a **pledge** until you send."
¹⁸ And **he** said, "What **pledge** shall I give you?"
 And **she** said, "**Your seal and your cord, and your staff** that is in your hand."
 And **he gave to her**
¹⁹ and **he went in to her**,
 and **she** conceived by **him**.
²⁰ And **she** arose and she went,
 and she removed her veil
 and she put on her widow's garments.

²⁰ And **Yehudah sent the young goat**
by the hand of **his friend the Adullamite**,
 to take the **pledge**
from the hand of the woman,
 and **he did not find her**.
²¹ And he asked the men of her place, saying,
 "Where is the **sacred woman** who was at Two-Eyes by the road?"
 And they said,
 "There has been no **sacred woman** here."
²² And he returned to Yehudah, and he said,
"I did not find her;
 and also, the men of the place said,
 'There has been no **sacred woman** here.' "
²³ And Yehudah said,
 "Let her keep them, lest we become an object of public contempt.
 Look, **I sent this young goat**, but **you did not find her**."

Genesis 38:12-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Genesis 38:12-23 contains five scenes arranged in a reverse symmetry (ABCB'A'). The central panel provides the pivot of this section. It focuses on Tamar's deception of Yehudah as she finds a way to overcome his deception of her.

The Symmetrical Design of Genesis 38:12-23

A – Genesis 38:12-13

- **Yehudah loses his wife to death**
- He goes with his buddy Hirah the Adullamite to celebrate **the shearing of his flock**

B – Genesis 38:14-16a

- **Tamar disguises herself as a prostitute**

- Yehudah wants to have sex with her

C – Genesis 38:16b-18a

- The dialogue & Tamar's deception
- In exchange for the **"sheep of his flock"** Tamar demands his seal, cord, and rod

B' – Genesis 38:18b-19

- Yehudah gives her the pledge and has sex with her
- **Tamar takes off her disguise**

A' – Genesis 38:20-23

- **Yehudah cannot find the sacred woman**
- He sends his buddy Hirah the Adullamite to give **the sheep of his flock**

Genesis 38:12-23. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

A and A': This match intensifies the gullibility and shame of Yehudah.

- He and Hirah go from a sheep-shearing festival (where the wine flows) in A to becoming bumbling idiots whose sexual escapades land them in a heap of trouble in A'.
- Yehudah goes from a festival with lots of sheep in A to losing one of his sheep in A', which is a mirror of Tamar, whose loss of a husband is reversed by her gaining of a child.

B and B': The reversal of Tamar's clothing (putting on the disguise/taking off the disguise) is symbolic of her plan: She is on a mission to reverse her status as the neglected widow in Yehudah's family.

C: The central focus of this unit is a pivot moment where Tamar goes from victim to victor by the mechanism of the "sheep of the flock," which of course links to the outer panels in A and A'.

- Tamar becomes the possessor of Yehudah's "rod," likely a sexual innuendo for his genitals, but also a link forward to Genesis 49:8-10 where Yehudah's "rod" becomes a symbol of the future royal seed.

A Disguised Deceiver

The central panel of the story is an inverted retelling of Genesis 3 with hints of the flood narrative.

Genesis 38	Genesis 3 & 6
Gen. 38:2 “And Yehudah saw there the daughter of a man ... and he took her.”	Gen. 3:6-7 “And the woman saw that the tree was good for eating ... and she took from its fruit and she ate ...”
Gen. 38:6 “And Yehudah took a wife for Er, his firstborn, and her name was Palm Tree/Tamar .”	
Gen. 38:7 “And Er his firstborn did what was bad in the eyes of Yahweh ” Gen. 38:10 “And it was bad in the eyes of Yahweh , what he did.”	Gen. 3:6-7 The tree of knowing good and bad was “ good in the eyes ” of the woman
Gen. 38:11 “Yehudah said to his daughter in law, ‘Dwell in the house of your father as a widow ...’ For he said, ‘ Lest he also die like his brothers.’”	Gen. 3:22 “The human has become like one of us, knowing good and evil, and now lest he send out his hand and take”
Gen. 38:14 Tamar “covered her face and disguised herself and sat by ‘ Opening of the Eyes ’ (פתח עינים) ... for she saw that Shelah had gotten older ... and she was not given to him as a wife .”	Gen. 3:6a “and the woman saw that ...” Gen. 3:6b “and she gave to her husband ...” Gen. 3:7 “and the eyes (עינים) of the two of them were opened (פקח) ...”
Gen. 38:21 “And [Yehudah] asked the men of the place, “ Where is the sacred prostitute that was by the Eyes (עינים)?”	
<i>Genesis 3 and 6 Present in Genesis 38. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

There is an inverted deception pattern: Yehudah, who was the deceiver in Genesis 37 and the deceiver of Tamar, is now deceived by her in response to his deception.

Just as the rebel spiritual being disguised itself as a snake to deceive the woman (Gen. 3), so here Tamar disguises herself to deceive her father-in-law. But notice the twist—Tamar’s deception is aimed at saving the life of the future seed, whereas the snake’s aim was to destroy the life of the future seed.

Yehudah replays the “see” and “take” fall pattern with regard to women (// sons of God in Gen. 6; Hagar in Gen. 16; Esau in Gen. 26, 27). But it’s his sons who end up dying as a result of their own “fall” narratives (“die” // Gen. 3). Tamar deceives Yehudah as he goes out to shear his sheep (Gen. 38:12). // Rachel deceives her father by stealing his idols when he goes out to shear his sheep (Gen. 31:19).

Tamar plays the role of the deceiver at Petakh-Enaim = “Opening of the Eyes” (Gen. 3:7) by covering her face and sleeping with her father-in-law (the daughters of Lot in Gen. 19).

Tamar's "covering her face" to deceive her father-in-law in 38:14-15 recalls Rebekah and Yaaqov's plan of covering Yaaqov's smooth skin with hair to deceive Isaac in Genesis 27.

Paragraph 3: Genesis 38:24-30

Yehudah Hears

- a 24 And it came about, three months later
that **it was reported to Yehudah** ,
b "Your daughter-in-law Tamar has been a **prostitute** ,
b' and behold, **she has conceived** by **prostitution** ."
a' And **Yehudah** said,
"**Make her come out** and let her be burned!"

Tamar Acts and Speaks

- a 25 As **she** was **being brought out**, she sent to her father-in-law, **saying** ,
b "**I have conceived by the man** to whom **these things** belong."
a' And **she said** ,
b' "Please **recognize** and see,
whose **seal and cords and staff** are these?"

Yehudah Sees

- a 26 And **Yehudah** **recognized** and he **said** ,
b "**She** is more righteous than **me**,
b' on account of the fact that **I** did not give **her** to Shelah my son."
a' And **he did not know** her again.

27 And it came about
at the time she was giving birth,
behold , there were twins in her womb.

- a 28 And it came about
as she was giving birth,
that he offered a **hand**,
b and the midwife took and bound **on his hand** a **scarlet** ,
c **saying** , "This one **came out** first."

- a' 29 And it came about
b' as he drew back **his hand**,

c' **behold**, his brother **came out**.
 d and **she said**, "What a **breach** you have **breached** for yourself!"
 And **he called his name "Breach/Perez"**

c' 30 And afterward his brother **came out**,
 b' who had **the scarlet on his hand**
 d' and **he called his name "Zerah/Sunrise."**

Genesis 38:24-30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This short unit brings Yehudah and Tamar's conflict to a climax. There are three scenes that alternate in an ABA' pattern that highlights the reversal of Yehudah's judgment on Tamar from condemnation to vindication.

- In Genesis 38:24, Yehudah hears the report and condemns Tamar to death.
- In Genesis 38:26, Yehudah sees the items and vindicates Tamar for acting on behalf of his future lineage.

Tamar's status moves from death to righteousness between A and A', all because of her deceptive scheme to subvert Yehudah's deception of her in Genesis 38:11.

Genesis 38:12-23	Genesis 38:24-26
Gen. 38:12-13 "and the days were many ... and it was reported to Tamar that ..."	Gen. 38:24 "three months later, and it was reported to Yehudah that ..."
Gen. 38:15 "and he considered her to be a prostitute " Gen. 38:18 "and she conceived by him"	Gen. 38:24 "your daughter-in-law Tamar has been a prostitute ... she has conceived by prostitution ."
Gen. 38:13 "your father in law has gone up ..."	Gen. 38:25 "she sent to her father in law ..."
Gen. 38:18 "your seal and cord and staff in your hand"	Gen. 38:25 "whose seal and cords and staff are these?"
Gen. 38:14 "and she was not given to [Shelah] as a wife"	Gen. 38:26 "for I had not given her to Shelah my son"
Gen. 38:16 "and he did not know that she was his daughter-in-law"	Gen. 38:26 "and he did not know her again"
Repeated Language in Genesis 38. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

These two central panels of Genesis 38 contain a whole series of inversions that are essential to the plot, as Tamar’s status is reversed by means of her counter-deception.

Rival Sons, Rival Dads

The birth of Yehudah’s sons as rival twins is a clear allusion back to the rival births of Yaaqov and Esau in [Genesis 25](#). This invites us to compare and contrast the stories and meditate on their similarities and differences.

The Birth of Perez and Zerah in Genesis 38:27-30	The Birth of Yaaqov and Esau in Genesis 25:24-26
And it came about for her to give birth (לדתה), and behold (והנה) there were twins in her belly (תאומים בבטנה)! As she gave birth, one put out his hand (יד), and the midwife took and tied a red thread (שני) on his hand (יד), saying “ This one came out first (ראשונה).” When he drew back his hand (ידו), his brother (אחיו) came out (יצא)! And she said, “What a breach you have breached for yourself!” And his name (שמו) was called (קרא) “Perez.” And after (ואחר), his brother (אחיו) upon whose hand (ידו) was the red thread (שני) came out (יצא). And his name (שמו) was called (קרא) “Zerah.”	And the days to give birth (ללדת) were filled up, and behold (והנה) twins in her belly (תאומים בבטנה)! The first (ראשון) came out (יצא) red (אדמוני) ... and they called his name (קרא שמו) “Esau.” Afterwards (ואחרי כן) his brother (אחיו) came out (יצא), with his hand (ידו) grabbing Esau’s heel (עקב), and they called his name (קרא שמו) “Yaaqov.”
The Births of Perez and Zerah, and Jacob and Esau. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 38: Yehudah & Tamar, Perez & Zerah	Genesis 25: Isaac & Rebekah, Esau & Yaaqov
Tamar is pregnant with twins	Rebecca pregnant with twins
Tamar uses deceptive garments in order to save the line of Yehudah	In Genesis 27, Rebekah sees that Isaac has put the promised line in jeopardy because of his appetite for food, so she uses deceptive garments to trick Isaac into blessing Yaaqov
One son (Zerah) sticks out his hand first and is tied with red, but is usurped by his brother Perez at birth	Esau comes out first all red, but is usurped as firstborn by his brother in the next story
Jacob and Esau Reflected in Perez and Zerah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 38: Yehudah & Tamar, Perez & Zerah

Genesis 25: Isaac & Rebekah, Esau & Yaaqov

The second-born (Perez) ends up claiming the status of the firstborn, and is named “Perez” because he has “broken out” (פרץ, **38:29**)

Yaaqov is described as “breaking out” (פרץ) when he overcomes his older uncle Laban (**Gen. 30:30, 43**)

Jacob and Esau Reflected in Perez and Zerah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

“The same motif of the ascendancy of the youngest son observed in the connection with Judah and Joseph repeats itself among their descendants. In the case of Judah’s sons, this motif occurs in the birth account of the twins, when Perez usurps Zerah as the first son to emerge from the womb. In the case of Joseph’s sons, this motif occurs later when Jacob reverses the expected order of the firstborn’s blessing and gives it to Ephraim rather than to his older brother Manasseh. This ... corresponds to the importance of these two tribes later in Israelite history when they become the central core of the Southern and Northern kingdoms. While the northern kingdom represented by Joseph remains relatively prosperous and mighty in comparison with its weaker neighbor in the south for at least two centuries, it is the southern kingdom of Judah that endures the exile. Eventually in the post-exilic period, the name Judah becomes synonymous with the Jewish people as a whole and with the Davidic dynasty ... unparalleled by any royal lineage in the north.”

Menn, Esther (1997). [*Yehudah and Tamar \(Genesis 38\) in Ancient Jewish Exegesis*](#). Brill. 81.

A Birth Narrative for the Royal Seed of David?

In contrast to the “barren wife” pattern in Genesis (Sarah, Rebekah, Rachel, Leah), Tamar’s problem is not infertility, but the absence of an appropriate male partner because of death and moral failure. This creates an affinity between Tamar and (1) Lot’s daughters ([Gen. 19:30-38](#)) and (2) Ruth.

- Like Lot’s daughters, the daughter must sleep with her father (in-law) to keep the family name alive. All three daughters use secrecy and deception to get their father drunk (like Noah in [Gen. 9](#)) so that he will impregnate them. Lot’s daughters give birth to Moab and Ammon, and of course, through Ruth, the line of Moab becomes part of the line of David. The birth narrative in [Genesis 19:30-38](#) introduces sons who play no role in the next narrative, but only later in the Torah and Prophets.
- Like Ruth, Tamar’s Israelite husband died and there is no longer an heir to marry, so a Levirate marriage must provide a solution. Ruth’s nighttime strategy attracts Boaz to marry her. Ruth is a Moabite, who becomes the ancestor of David. The birth narrative in [Ruth 4](#) is abrupt and introduces characters who are still far off in narrative time.

These three narratives of Tamar, Lot’s daughters, and Ruth form an interconnected whole that provide a kind of “birth narrative” for David. This is hugely significant, as 1 Samuel provides no birth narrative for David, but simply introduces David as a “son of Jesse,” already a young man in the reign of Saul ([1 Sam. 16-17](#)). The

absence of a birth narrative for David is conspicuous, as he is one of the most important characters in the Hebrew Bible. And yet, unlike Abraham, Yaakov, Yoseph, Moses, Samuel, Solomon, and so on, David has no birth narrative. These three narratives ([Gen. 19:30-38](#); ch. 38; Ruth) provide a “hyperlinked” birth narrative for David.

All three narratives portray the origins of the line of David in an unflattering light, involving sex scandals, but also the strange work of divine providence in and through compromised people.

The book of Ruth is full of hyperlinks and design patterns that connect to [Genesis 38](#), especially the concluding genealogy.

Yehudah and Tamar in Genesis 38	Boaz and Ruth in Ruth 4
Yehudah’s deception puts his own lineage at risk	Boaz’s faithfulness to the role of the kinsmen redeemer rescues the line of David from death
Tamar engages in a sexually charged deception to save the lineage of Yehudah	Ruth engages in a sexually charged deception to save her mother-in-law and ends up saving the lineage of Yehudah
Yehudah and his sons fail to “raise up seed for their brother” in Levirate marriage	Boaz commits to “raise up the name” of their brother in Levirate marriage
Tamar is likened to Rebekah, who also gives birth to twins	Ruth is likened to Tamar, Rachel, and Leah Ruth 4:11-12 “May the Lord make the woman who is coming into your home like Rachel and Leah , both of whom built the house of Israel; and may you achieve wealth in Ephrathah and become famous in Bethlehem. Moreover, may your house be like the house of Perez whom Tamar bore to Yehudah , through the offspring which the Lord will give you by this young woman.”
Comparing Genesis 38 and Ruth 4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Intertextual Links Between Genesis 38 and 2 Samuel 11-13

David’s affair is with Bat-Sheva’ ([2 Sam. 11:3](#)) // Judah sleeps with Bat-Shua’ ([Gen. 38:2, 12](#)) → Solomon’s mother Bat-Sheva’ is actually named Bat-Shua’ in [1 Chronicles 3:5](#)!

The affair results in the death of David’s first two sons: Amnon, and eventually Absalom. // Judah’s two sons die.

The plot of both [Genesis 38](#) and [2 Samuel 13](#) revolves around illicit sex with a woman named “Palm Tree” = Tamar.

Both Tamars are vindicated at a sheep-shearing festival ([1 Sam. 13:23](#) // [Gen. 38:13](#)).

The names involved in both plot series are matched.

Genesis 38	2 Samuel 11-13
Judah יהודה	דוד David
Hirah חיר ה	חירם Hiram
Adullamite עדלמי	עדלם Adullam (1 Sam. 22:1; 23:13)
Bat-Shua בת שו ע	עבט Bat-Sheva (called Bat-Shua in 1 Chr. 3:5)
Er ער	נער David’s stillborn son (2 Sam. 12:16)
Onan אונן	נאמ Amnon
Shelah שלה	שלמה Solomon
Tamar תמר	תמר Tamar

Comparing Genesis 38 and 2 Samuel 11-13. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Reflection Question

What positive message about the character of God can we glean from the three-part birth narrative for David’s lineage in the hyperlinked stories of Tamar, Lot’s daughters, and Ruth?